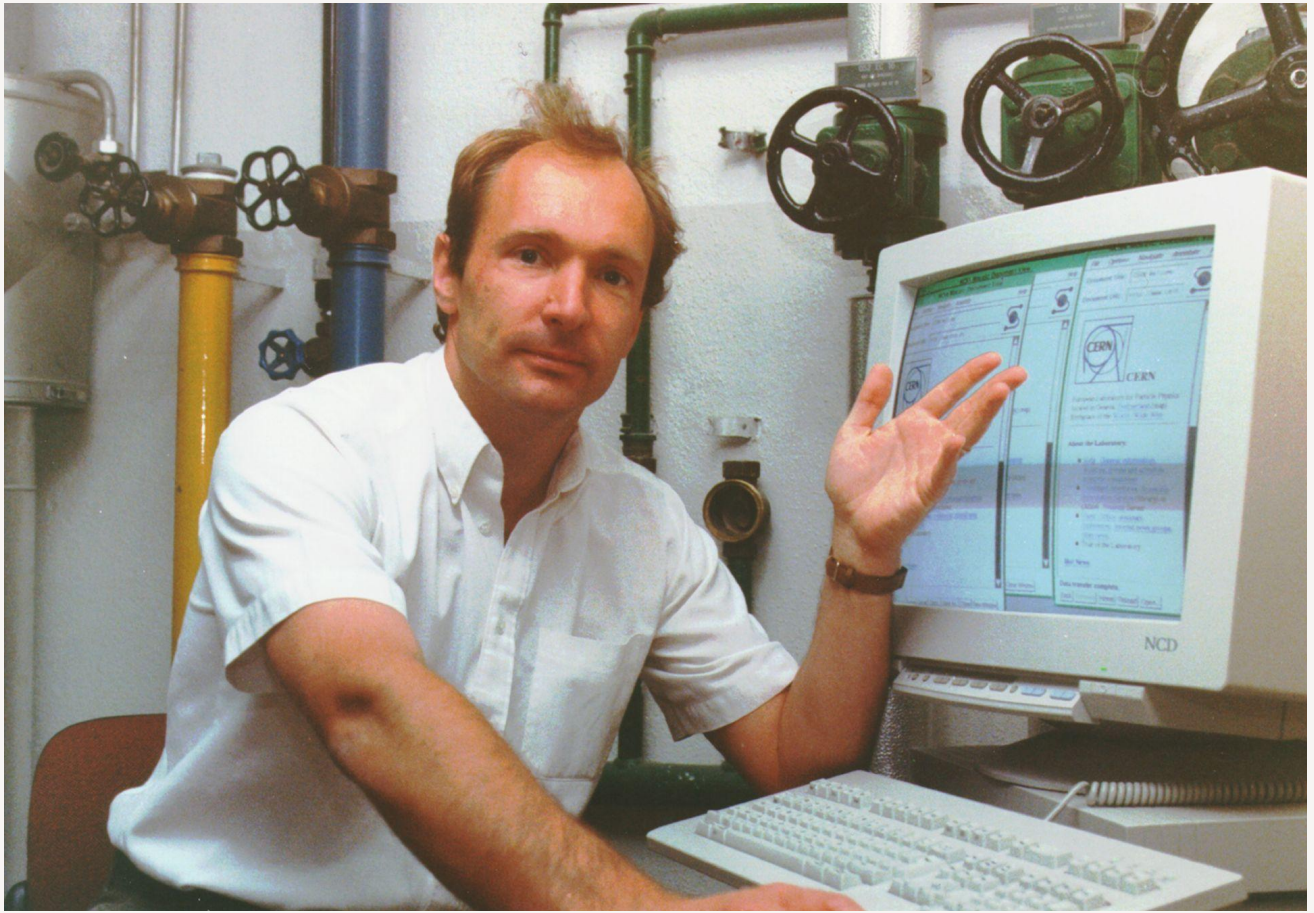
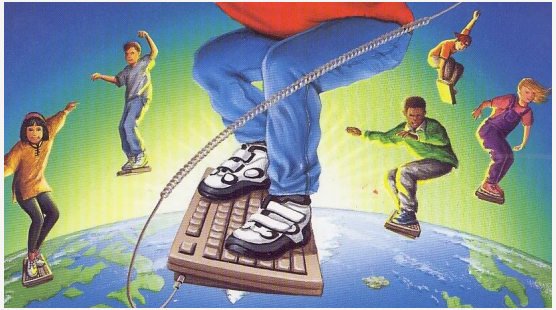
The social web: what went wrong and what could be

Idealism and the internet

The early days of the internet and the web were full of idealism. The social web allowed people to connect, organise, and speak in new ways.



1990s



THE EARLY DAYS

The Web was designed to be open; a series of standards anyone could use to build a page of text, and later, images. It was a literal “web”, with hyperlinks helping users “surf” networks of sites.

Search engines like Google (launched 1998) made networks easier to navigate, initially ranking search results on links to a page, a proxy for trustworthiness.

Early 2000s



SEARCH

Early 2000s laws shielded websites from legal liabilities, birthing “Web 2.0”. Social media and video sharing platforms emerged, prioritising user generated content and a participatory culture.

At first the social and searchable web seemed to supercharge the idealism of the web.

Search engines made access to the world’s information open to anyone with a connection.

Late 2000s



THE SOCIAL WEB

The late 2000s saw the rise of the social web. The social web allowed people to connect, organise, and speak in new ways.

It saw the launch of YouTube (acquired by Google for $1.6 billion in Google stock in 2006) and the rise of Facebook (with Sheryl Sandberg joining in 2008 from Google’s ad division).

2010s

THE ARAB SPRING

The pinnacle of internet optimism was the Arab Spring, a wave of protests that swept the Middle East and North Africa between 2010 and 2012.

The demonstrations were led by young people, and in some cases led to the overthrow of long-serving autocratic rulers.

While the impact of smartphones and social media has since become the subject of debate, a narrative took hold that these had been essential organising tools for the uprisings, especially in Egypt and Tunisia. It felt like we were witnessing the dawn of a new era of democracy.



> **BACK THEN, MY VIEW WAS WE WERE UNLEASHING THIS INCREDIBLE TOOL FOR DEMOCRACY AND TO HELP LIFT MARGINALISED VOICES...**

> **...I DON'T THINK ANY OF US FORESAW WHERE IT WAS GOING TO GO...**

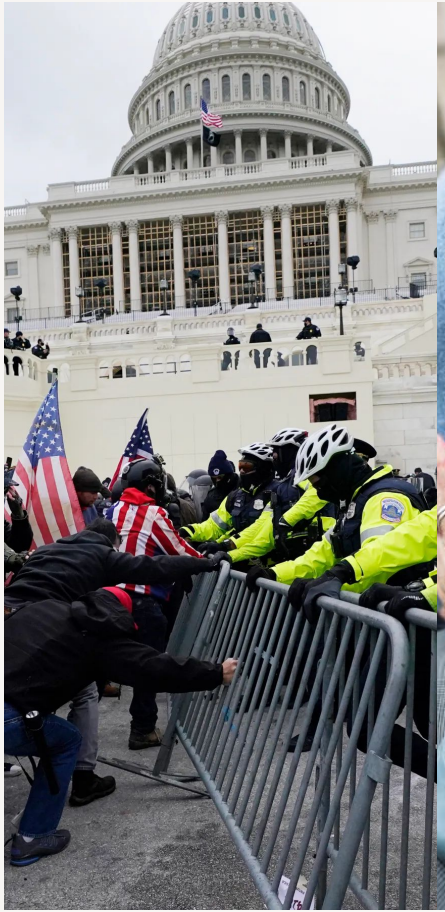
AL GORE, FORMER VICE-PRESIDENT

THE CRISIS

Fast forward to today

All that idealism is gone.

Instead, we have an internet that supercharges the spread of misinformation, hate speech and incitement, polarisation, election manipulation and interference, the erosion of privacy, and the undermining of trust in institutions and science.









Violence and hatred

We have an internet that incites violence and hatred. Hate speech online has been linked to a global increase in violence toward minorities, including attacks on refugees in Germany, lynchings in India, and mass shootings in the US and New Zealand.



Disinformation

We have an internet that supercharges the spread of mis- and disinformation. Social media has been found to propel false information far faster than truth, eroding trust in things like the science of climate change.



Erosion of privacy

We have seen the steady erosion of privacy. The surveillance advertising business model relies on mass data collection of internet users on and offline, which can be weaponised against those, for example, seeking access to reproductive health care.

6x

Lies spread six times faster than the truth on social media. Moving faster and more broadly than the truth in every kind of information category.

“

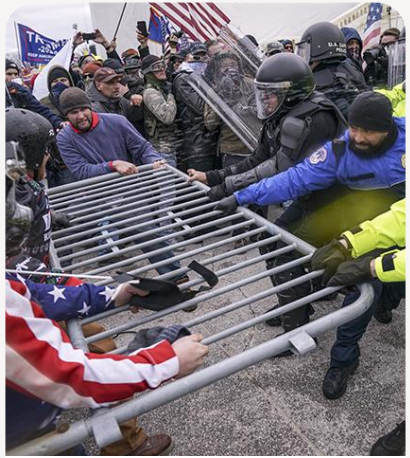
“Instead of this being a golden age of the democratisation of knowledge, it’s turned into something very different from what any of us expected. The last 20 years have seen, especially the last decade, the wholesale destruction of privacy.”

Shoshana Zuboff



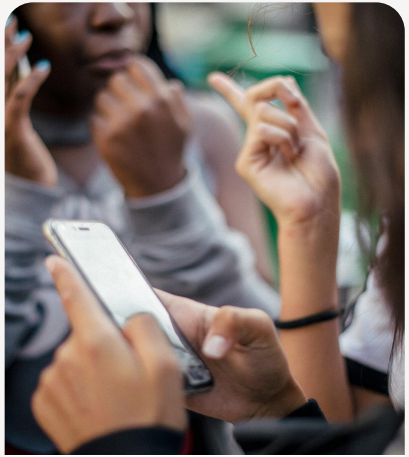
Decline in democracy

We are seeing record declines in democracy globally, with technology facilitating this, from enabling election manipulation and interference to eroding trust in institutions.



Polarisation

Social media has increased political polarisation, which is fueling increasing political violence around the world, in the US, Brazil and elsewhere. It has been shown over time to erode democratic norms, trust and institutions.



Fostering addiction

Social media is designed to identify what will elicit a strong emotional response from users and show more and more content along the same themes. This includes children, and content that promotes a negative body image or self-harm.

32

The number of liberal democracies fell from 44 countries in 2009 to 32 in 2022

1/3

of girls aged 11-15 feel “addicted” to social media and half of teenagers report that it would be hard to give up scrolling

What went wrong?

It didn’t have to be this way. We can trace the turning point for the internet to four key decisions made at a critical point in the 2010s. None of these decisions were inevitable, or are irreversible.







Four decisions that shaped the social web

These were choices, made by humans, and in the interest of profit and market dominance. They shaped the dominant business model of the modern web, one built on data hoarding, addictive and toxic algorithms, and systems prioritising profit over people.

FOUR DECISIONS:

01

Monetising our data and engagement

The business model, based on highly targeted ads, made companies like Google and Facebook some of the most valuable in history. And some of the most harmful.

02

Keeping us scrolling; the attention economy

The creation of the algorithm to continuously play videos was designed to maximise user engagement, thus increasing ad revenue, but it often led users to extremist and radicalising content.

03

Making deals in emerging markets to become 'the internet'

Social media expanded without an understanding of the local context, without accountability, and without language capabilities or content moderation.

04

Regulatory failure: allowing firms to buy up rivals

Consolidation created staggering financial and market corporate power. Power now being used against attempts to regulate the industry.

What do we mean by the Business Model?

Search and social companies profit from selling ads; a business model that prioritises engagement over truth and safety.

Platforms constantly and intrusively surveil online behaviour to help advertisers understand and target audiences.

They design products to maximise engagement. Algorithms curate a user's experience to optimise for attention, even if that means actively promoting content that is polarising, hateful, or simply untrue.

01

Monetising our data and attention: the surveillance ads business model

Companies like Google and Facebook used ads to generate revenue from their early years. But it was the switch to a business model based on highly targeted ads that made them the most valuable companies in history.

And some of the most harmful.

Allowing advertisers to place highly targeted ads has enabled discriminatory exclusion of, for example, people of colour from housing ads. It has also incentivised:

- Mass surveillance and data gathering on users of platforms, on and offline
- Addictive algorithms designed to maximise the time users spend on platforms
- Anti-competitive mergers to build monopolies with “better” targeting data
- Prioritisation of information away from quality and towards paid reach and content that elicits more engagement



> “IT MIGHT BE NICE TO GET SOME ADS GOING TO OFFSET THE COST OF THE SERVERS.

MARK ZUCKERBERG, Speaking to the Harvard Crimson two months after launching TheFacebook, March 2004

02

Keeping us scrolling; the attention economy

YouTube introduced Autoplay in 2015, allowing an algorithm to continuously play videos. Within 3 years, the algorithm would drive 70% of what people see on the platform.

The algorithm aimed to maximise user engagement, thus increasing ad revenue, but it often led users to extremist and policy-violating content.

Similar algorithms on platforms like Facebook and TikTok also prioritise emotive or extreme content, with TikTok's method potentially steering young viewers towards harmful content promoting self-harm or suicide.

A New York Times report on a leaked TikTok document explaining how the algorithm works explained that in the pursuit of TikTok's 'ultimate goal' of adding daily active users it, 'has chosen to optimize for two closely related metrics in the stream of videos it serves: 'retention' — that is, whether a user comes back — and 'time spent.' The app wants to keep you there as long as possible.'

Non-English speakers are especially affected, and suffer from chronic underinvestment in protections like content moderation.

What is the Attention Economy?
A commercial recognition of attention as a scarce and valuable commodity, leading to consumers being offered online content or services which they are seeking in return for allowing themselves to be exposed to promotional messages.

> Behind every screen on your phone, there are generally like literally a thousand engineers that have worked on this thing to try to make it maximally addicting...It's as if they're taking behavioural cocaine and just sprinkling it all over your interface and that's the thing that keeps you like coming back and back and back.
>
> Aza Raskin,
> Inventor of the infinite scroll

03

Making deals in emerging markets to become ‘the internet’

As social media companies reached market saturation in the US and Europe, they targeted emerging markets. They struck deals with phone carriers in countries where internet access was relatively expensive, offering versions of their apps for free. "Facebook Zero" launched in 2010, expanding to Kenya, the Philippines, Pakistan, and similar initiatives covering Myanmar, Nigeria, Iraq, India, and Algeria. Twitter (now X) soon followed suit.

This solidified platforms like Facebook as the primary means of internet access in many countries, with a substantial portion of the population regarding "Facebook as the Internet" by 2015.

By this time companies were fully aware their products needed moderation for issues like hate speech, and this was a major expenditure in the US and EU.

However Facebook and Twitter actively expanded to fragile countries without an understanding or presence in the local context, without accountability, and without investing in language capabilities or content moderation.

The result was often catastrophic.

65%

of Nigerians agreed with the statement that "Facebook is the Internet" in 2015

87%

of Facebook resources to counter harms are spent in North America, where just 9% if users live

04

Regulatory failure: allowing firms to buy up rivals

Regulators largely failed to prevent acquisitions by tech giants like Meta and Google over the past two decades.

These include Meta's purchases of rivals Instagram and WhatsApp, and Google's purchase of YouTube and multiple parts of the online ad system like DoubleClick.

Meta and Google's acquisition enabled them to dominate social media, online advertising, and search engines. It also allowed them to exploit vast stores of data, which are now providing unfair advantages in the AI race.

The global concentration of content platforms also created disinformation vulnerabilities at global scale. And it made competition next to impossible, meaning consumers can't opt out, leaving users little choice but to accept online surveillance and privacy violations.

But crucially, this consolidation allowed for the accumulation of financial and market power at a never before seen scale. With valuations larger than most countries, corporate power is now being deployed against attempts to regulate the industry, and to deal with the social and political fall out of harms.

$17 trillion

By 2020 Google (Alphabet), Amazon, Apple, Microsoft and Facebook were worth $7.5 trillion, up from $7.5 trillion in 2020.

269+

Google (Alphabet) has acquired 269 companies in its lifetime.